The Approaches to the Study of IR: Theories and Methodologies

In reality, the complexities in IR makes it impossible to study with a limited knowledge. What is needed is a systematic analysis of the subject matter of IR. For this, as Goldstein[27] observes that both descriptive and theoretical knowledge are required as he contends that "It would do little good only to describe events without being able to generalize or draw lessons from them. Nor would it do much good to formulate purely abstract theories without being able to apply them to the finely detailed and complex real world in which we live". Equally important is the use of methods in developing and testing various theories. Whether one builds theories from facts or predict facts from theories, one can utilize them to the learning of IR in myriad ways. But given the complexities and unpredictability of IR, it can be said that even the best theories provide only a rough guide to understand the international processes and interactions and eventually make decisions.

Nevertheless, overtime different paradigms in IR which sparked grand debates have ultimately led to the gradual evolution of the discipline as already discussed. The main debates in IR are between:

1. Utopian Liberalism/Idealism and Realism
2. Traditional Approaches and Behaviouralism
3. Neo-liberalism/neo-Realism and neo-Marxism
4. Positivism and post-Positivist Alternatives.

Most IR scholars do agree that a single set of theories or even a single set of concepts would not be in a position to explain IR. Still three paradigms are found to dominate the study of IR.

1. Realism and neo-realism
2. Liberalism, pluralism and neo-liberalism
3. International political economy—structuralism and neo-Marxism.

Scholars like Abdul A. Said[17] observed that five categories of theories have emerged to examine the unexplored terrain of international relations: